‘I’ve interacted with all the other candidates, and I plan to keep in touch with them, Sir, regardless of how things pan out,’ I replied. I didn’t want them to think I was partial and avoided telling them that Hema was the only one I could call a ‘friend’ there. But the truth was that I had interacted with all of them. The IO then asked me basic questions about my family and education. The more I talked, the more relaxed I felt. But there was one question that made me stop and think for a while.

‘Tell us why you want to join the Indian Air Force?’

I knew the answer to this question. I had prepared for it all my life. What I did not know was how to frame my answer. Should I sound passionate? What if I sounded desperate instead? How could I tackle this? What should I say to convince them? There was no time to plan or prepare. I had to be quick.

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September 1984

The road to Etawah was shining wet from a fresh drizzle. Papaji and I were riding a scooter he had borrowed from a course mate in Jhansi. Beauty had given birth to a litter and all of us wanted the pups to go to caring and responsible families. So Papaji had taken it upon himself to deliver them to some of his acquaintances who were willing to adopt them. The last of the litter was travelling with us to his new home in the scooter’s front basket. We had stopped by a roadside tea stall to keep ourselves from getting wet in the drizzle. I didn’t want the puppy to catch a fever. It was asleep on my lap while Papaji and I sipped tea from earthen cups; a mixed aroma of hot tea and rain-washed earth perfumed the air. It had stopped raining and we had to reach our destination before sundown, so we finished our tea and got up to get going after paying the chaiwallah. Just then, we heard the shutter of a nearby garage opening. Papaji paused midway into kick-starting his scooter as something inside the garage caught his eye. He put the scooter back on the stand and started to walk towards the garage. I trotted behind him,